The Man with Night Sweats

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The Man with Night Sweats

This revision guide to Thom Gunn's poem 'The Man with Night Sweats', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4 anthology, includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line breakdown of the poem, including its possible meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods**: an exploration of the techniques and poetic choices that Gunn has used
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas in the poem

Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is important to keep in mind that, while the poem will be printed on your exam paper, you are still expected to make reference to the poem and use accurate, relevant quotations to show thorough knowledge and understanding. Make sure you focus on the key words in the question and annotate the poem with the question in mind.

Be sure to structure your response clearly and write your analysis in chronological order of the poem.

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is vital that you understand what it is about. This section includes:

- The poem in a nutshell
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Gunn's intention and message

'The Man with Night Sweats' in a nutshell

'The Man with Night Sweats' was written by Thom Gunn in 1992. It is a poem centred on a man suffering at the hands of a

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

'The Man with Night Sweats' breakdown

Lines 1–4

> **"I wake up cold, I who**
> **Prospered through dreams of heat**
> **Wake to their residue,**
> **Sweat, and a clinging sheet."**

Translation

- The speaker describes waking up covered in sweat, even though he is cold

Gunn's intention

- This is the first **quatrain** in the poem and the speaker is introduced
- The speaker uses the contrast between "cold" and "heat" to highlight the difference between his past and present self:
  - He "prospered through dreams of heat" but now wakes up "cold"
  - Heat could symbolise **vigour** and passion as well as the literal effects of a fever
  - The use of the word "cold" carries negative connotations as it could symbolise fear, loneliness and panic, which could be what the speaker is experiencing
- However, upon waking, they are confronted with the coldness of their surroundings, which serves as a stark contrast to the warmth of their dreams
- The speaker notes that, upon waking, they are left with the "residue" of their dreams, which manifests as sweat:
  - The use of the word "residue" conveys a sense of something lingering, emphasising the lasting impact of the dreams on the speaker's experience
- Gunn's use of the sensory imagery of "sweat" and a "clinging sheet" evokes sensations of discomfort and unease and implies that the speaker is suffering from an illness
- The opening stanza contributes to the overall atmosphere of the poem, conveying a sense of intimacy and vulnerability
- This quatrain has an alternating rhyme scheme (ABAB) and this regular pattern could reflect the speaker's desire to keep their emotions contained and controlled:
  - The short sentences and use of **caesura** helps to keep the speaker's emotions contained

Lines 5–6

> **"**

Help me understand

Translation

- The speaker describes how his body served as a barrier that would take care of itself

Gunn's intention

- The speaker uses metaphorical language to describe their flesh as a "shield":
  - This metaphor suggests that the speaker's physical body was a protective barrier that shielded them from harm or injury
  - The imagery of a shield conveys a sense of strength and resilience, implying that the speaker's flesh was capable of withstanding external threats and preserving their well-being
  - A shield could also link to ideas of warriors and battles and so the speaker could be suggesting that they used to feel powerful and strong

- The speaker further emphasises the former resilience of their flesh by noting that "where it was gashed, it healed":
  - This suggests that the speaker's flesh had the ability to heal itself
  - This imagery of healing reinforces the idea of resilience and strength, highlighting the speaker's capacity to overcome adversity and recover from physical wounds

- However, it is important to note that the speaker is speaking in the past tense, which could suggest that his body no longer responds to injury or harm in the way it used to
- This stanza is a full rhyming **couplet**, which could reflect the speaker's former self-assuredness and confidence

Lines 7–10

> **"I grew as I explored**
> **The body I could trust**
> **Even while I adored**
> **The risk that made robust,"**

Translation

- The speaker reflects on their relationship with their own body and their journey of self-discovery

Gunn's intention

- The speaker describes how they "grew" as they "explored the body I could trust":
  - The act of exploration implies a sense of curiosity and discovery as the speaker navigated the complexities of their physical and emotional experiences

- The first line of the stanza could also hint at the speaker's sexual journey of discovery:

that made robust", which suggests they had a willingness to embrace challenges even as they acknowledge the potential for danger or harm
- The juxtaposition of "adore" and "risk" highlights the speaker's complex relationship with their own body as they found beauty and strength in the actions that made them vulnerable:
    - This highlights the speaker's former resilience and willingness to confront challenges head-on, rather than shy away from them

- Gunn's use of enjambment here could reflect the speaker's excitement and youth

Lines 11–12

> **"A world of wonders in**
> **Each challenge to the skin."**

Translation

- The speaker describes the opportunities that they experienced

Gunn's intention

- The phrase "world of wonders" suggests that the speaker found "each challenge to the skin" exciting:
    - The phrase "challenge to the skin" could refer to the physical and emotional challenges that the speaker faced, suggesting that these experiences were rich with meaning and significance

- The speaker clearly found his youth thrilling and exciting as he "grew" from each experience and "wonder"
- Another full rhyming couplet is used again here to reflect the speaker's youthful confidence and self-assuredness

Lines 13–16

> **"I cannot but be sorry**
> **The given shield was cracked**
> **My mind reduced to hurry,**
> **My flesh reduced and wrecked"**

Translation

- The speaker expresses regret and reflects on how he has been affected both physically and mentally

Gunn's intention

- Gunn has used the metaphor of a "shield" again but this time to highlight that it is "cracked":
    - This highlights how fragile and vulnerable their body has become

- The speaker further reflects on the consequences of their illness, noting that their mental state is "reduced to hurry" and their body is "reduced and wrecked":
  - These lines convey the profound impact of the illness on both the speaker's mental and physical well-being
  - "Reduced to hurry" suggests a state of anxiety or agitation

- The lines convey a sombre and introspective tone as the speaker grapples with the physical and emotional challenges of illness:
  - The use of words like "sorry", "reduced" and "wrecked" conveys a sense of sadness and **resignation**

Lines 17–18

> **"I have to change the bed,**
> **But catch myself instead"**

Translation

- The speaker states that they have to change the bedsheets but is instead preoccupied with himself

Gunn's intention

- Gunn has bought the speaker back to the present day
- The speaker has to complete the practical task of changing the bedsheets but the phrase "catch myself" suggests that the speaker is caught up in his own **turmoil**:
  - This turmoil could either be physical or mental

- It is worth noting that this couplet is different from the rest of the couplets in the poem as it uses enjambment to flow into the next stanza:
  - This could reflect a change in the speaker's emotions and a lack of control or a feeling of being overwhelmed

Lines 19–22

> **"Stopped upright where I am**
> **Hugging my body to me**
> **As if to shield it from**
> **The pains that will go through me,"**

Translation

- The speaker holds himself as he feels pain go through him

Gunn's intention

- The speaker describes hugging their body and the word "shield" is used in an attempt to protect themselves from anticipated "pains" or discomfort:

and that his attempts to "shield" himself from "the pains" are **futile**
- Also the phrase "hugging my body to me" suggests that the speaker is completely alone and isolated

Lines 23–24

> **"As if hands were enough**
> **To hold the avalanche off."**

Translation

- The speaker is highlighting the level of pain he is feeling and how his hands are the only things holding it off

Gunn's intention

- In the final couplet, the metaphor of "the avalanche" suggests a **monumental** and unstoppable force that threatens to overwhelm the speaker
- The imagery of the speaker trying to hold off an avalanche with just their hands conveys a sense of futility and desperation:
  - It implies that the speaker feels powerless and overwhelmed by the pain and challenge they face

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into three separate sections – form, structure and language – it is always best to move from **what** the poet is presenting (the techniques they use; the overall form of the poem; what comes at the beginning, middle and end of a poem) to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have.

Focusing on the poet's overarching ideas, rather than individual poetic techniques, will gain you far more marks. Crucially, in the sections below, all analysis is arranged by theme, and includes Gunn's intentions behind his choices in terms of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem generally has a regular rhyme scheme and is loosely written in **iambic trimeter**.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention

	ABAB CC that is consistent throughout the poem	speaker's desire for control and calm, which is in contrast to his illness and the pain that he is experiencing
	The poem is predominantly iambic trimeter, with six syllables per line: the first syllable is unstressed and the second is stressed. This creates a rhythmic pattern	The iambic trimeter could **mimic** the speaker's breathing and again could reflect his desire for control and calm

Structure

This poem is written in eight stanzas that alternate between quatrains and rhyming couplets.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Illness and vulnerability	There are a total of 24 lines in the poem, which are organised into four quatrains and four couplets The poem has regular rhymes and short lines, making it tight and contained	The tightly contained and neatly arranged stanzas could reflect the speaker's desire to contain his emotions, much like his hands are attempting to contain his physical pain

Language

Gunn uses a number of literary devices in the poem to highlight how the disease has taken a toll on the speaker.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Mortality	The poem is written in first person with the speaker using "I" when talking of his illness	This creates an immediate connection between the reader and the speaker of the poem as he contemplates his past vigour and his present illness

	and body. At the start of the poem his body is described as a "shield", which protected him from challenges. However, at the end of the poem, the "shield" is "cracked"	speaker's vulnerability and mortality. His youth and vigour have disappeared and his body is now **susceptible** to disease and illness
	The writer changes tenses throughout the poem. He speaks in past tense when he is healthy and uses words with positive connotations such as "prospered", "adored" and "wonders"	The changes in tenses and language highlight the speaker's vulnerability and change in the speaker's health. He is aware of his mortality and how he has now become weak
	However, the language changes when he talks of the present tense and he uses words with negative connotations such as "cold", "sweat", "sorry", "reduced" and "wrecked"	

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